SELARIN

A PLAYER HISTORY

Six ages. Living kingdoms. Unanswered mysteries.



THE AGE OF INHERITANCE

A world of established kingdoms, crowded ports, and roads that pass things no living scholar can explain.

742 AR • Illustrated player edition

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Map of Selarin



The realms in 742 AR. Capitals, settlements, routes, and ancient waystones connect a continent of cold northern reaches, mountain holds, river plains, and southern coasts.

Welcome to Selarin

A world in the Age of Inheritance

Selarin is a world of established kingdoms, working farms, crowded ports, and roads that pass things no living scholar can explain. A ruler may claim a throne older than the surviving chronicles. A village may hold its market beside a stone that has never weathered. Above a ruined city, a chamber may still hang in the air, with no stair, door, or spell known to reach it.

This history introduces the world your character inhabits: its six great ages, the gods whose stories shaped them, and the powers that govern the present. It records the broad account taught by chroniclers, temples, and travelers. Where their traditions disagree, those disagreements are part of Selarin itself.

The present is the year 742 of the Accord Reckoning. The major realms are at peace, although frontier raids, disputed tolls, and old territorial claims still bring people into conflict. Most lives are shaped by family, work, weather, and local obligations. Adventurers travel beyond those familiar boundaries, where the past has left both opportunities and dangers.

Reading the history

The first ages survive through sacred stories, archaeology, and fragments copied long after their originals were lost. Later centuries have treaties, household records, and witnesses whose descendants still dispute what happened. A story accepted in one temple may be questioned in the next city. The existence of the gods is widely accepted; the accuracy of every account told about them is another matter.

The Six Ages

A chronology of Selarin

The Accord Reckoning begins with the settlement of Veycross, which reopened several important trade routes after the Sundering. The first year is 1 AR. Earlier dates are written BR, meaning Before the Reckoning; there is no year zero. Ancient boundaries are estimates, and neighboring civilizations often entered or left an age at different times.

Beneath Memory

Before about 9000 BR

Creation traditions, the oldest gods, and stories of the Deep Heart

First Peoples

About 9000 to 4200 BR

Early realms, the First Courts, and the first surviving accounts of ascension

Great Works

About 4200 to 1300 BR

The Concord of Towers, Covenant Cities, and wonders beyond modern mastery

Disagreement

About 1300 to 420 BR

Rival claims to magical prosperity, religious divisions, and failed settlements

Sundering Years

420 to 1 BR

Collapsing networks, migrations, lost cities, and enduring acts of rescue

Inheritance

1 AR to the present year 742 AR

The modern realms, renewed trade, and a world with its own ambitions

The Living World

Seasons, magic, and waystones



A waystone beside an old road. Customs endure where explanations have been lost.

Seasons and the Long Breath

Spring, summer, autumn, and winter ordinarily follow familiar patterns. Beneath them, observers recognize a slower, uneven rhythm called the Long Breath. Over decades or centuries, forests grow more vigorously, magical creatures alter their migrations, and places once rich in ambient magic become quieter. Some regions remain consistently more magical than others.

Breathweather is the common name for unusual disturbances associated with these changes. Snow may fall during summer. Warm winter winds may release dangerous floods. A crownstorm can turn for days over inland country, while tremors change springs or close a mountain road. Most communities experience long intervals of ordinary weather between serious events. Agriculture and travel remain possible because catastrophe is exceptional.

What an ordinary traveler knows

Magic is a fact of life, although access varies greatly. A Serathian city supports academies and licensed practitioners; a remote Vardane valley may depend on one shrine keeper and an occasional visiting healer. A region with little ambient magic does not routinely prevent a wizard from casting spells or a priest from receiving divine aid.

Ancient waystones stand across the realms. Their surfaces scarcely show the passage of time, and ordinary tools cannot cut them. People build roads, shrines, and markets around them. Their makers and purpose remain matters of argument. A traveler is more likely to hear a local custom about a stone than a convincing explanation of it.

In settled country, sightings of monstrous creatures are noteworthy rather than routine. Local watches collect credible reports of griffons, trolls, owlbears, and other hazards; experienced carriers know which streams, nesting cliffs, and stretches of road merit caution. A market may sell griffon feathers or warding tokens without having a griffon anywhere near its walls.

The Age Beneath Memory

Before about 9000 BR

No account of Selarin's beginning can be checked against a surviving mortal record. The oldest hymns describe a world still taking shape, where earth had not settled and the first forests repeatedly vanished beneath fire, frost, or sea. Some tell of gods making order. Others place the gods within a world already alive.

The stories of the Deep Heart

Across otherwise unrelated traditions appears the image of something immense beneath the earth. Mountain songs call it the First Sleeper. River prayers speak of a heart too large for the sky. Later scholars gathered these stories under the name Deep Heart, although they disagree about whether the term describes a being, a natural power, or a poetic explanation of the Long Breath.

In one familiar tale, Ilyra spreads roots over the earth while Ordan gives the mountains their foundations. Thessar refuses to still the winds, insisting that growing things must have movement and room to change. Their bargain creates a world that can endure without becoming motionless. It is often recited when a community plants a new orchard or raises a boundary stone.

Malrec's temples preserve a different telling. They credit a first sovereign who commanded the unruly earth to submit. Worshippers of Ilyra answer that no command can make a field fertile forever. Neither tradition supplies proof of what lies beneath the land, but each has influenced how rulers understand their obligations to it.

The first divine quarrels

The oldest surviving religious traditions name Ilyra, Ordan, Thessar, and Sovan among the powers present before organized mortal kingdoms. Sovan appears as the keeper of the first passage between life and death. In the Tale of the Unburied Morning, he leads the dead away so that grief does not hold the living in an endless day. His shrines still leave a door or window open during a funeral.

Mereth's mercy and Nharos's hunger enter the stories when living creatures begin to suffer. Mereth tends a wounded beast that can offer her neither prayer nor repayment. Nharos consumes what others need and calls survival his only law. Their conflict remains central to disputes over healing, famine relief, and the use of another person's life to extend one's own.

Avariel's earliest legend concerns a judge who places her own seat beneath the law she announces. Malrec calls that act a surrender of rightful power. Varkhul appears in tales of destruction that outlast its cause, while Drazha is the pursuer who continues the hunt after hunger is satisfied. These stories provide moral language rather than a reliable order of divine births.

What remains of the age

Unnaturally warm valleys, strange seams of stone, and deep places that trouble sleepers are sometimes attributed to these first events. Natural causes, older magic, and religious explanations compete. Even the longest dwarven genealogies stop far short of this age. Its importance lies in the customs it established: burial as a duty, rule as an obligation, and the belief that the land has rhythms no crown can wholly command.

Creatures in the oldest stories

The oldest mountain songs speak of dragons already old when the peaks first rose, of vast serpents beneath tidal waters, and of giants who measured their steps by the shaping of the land. Scholars do not claim that such stories describe a single forgotten kingdom. They do note that some living creatures thrive in places of unusual heat, deep stone, and enduring magic. To a traveler today, the lesson is simple: the oldest wilderness may shelter life that no familiar bestiary fully explains.

The Age of First Peoples

About 9000 to 4200 BR

The earliest recoverable histories concern communities that learned where they could remain. Families settled river terraces, sheltered coasts, and mountain valleys. They kept observations of harvests and animal migrations, passing them through song before committing them to bark, clay, and stone. These peoples were diverse from the beginning. Later claims that any one ancestry alone built civilization tell us more about royal ambition than ancient life.

The First Courts

The societies now grouped together as the First Courts developed an unusually close relationship with living magic. Some grew halls from trees without killing them. Others preserved testimony in groves or established roads whose course depended on remembered agreements. Their courts were separate communities, often rivals, rather than provinces of one empire.

Elven lineages preserved much of their ceremonial language, which explains Elaran's strong connection to their legacy. Yet surviving images show many peoples attending those courts. Hospitality, inheritance, and the right to alter a landscape were persistent concerns. A dispute about cutting timber might involve the needs of a village, a lord's claim, and promises made by grandparents to a place they considered alive.

Nivara and the Open Song

Nivara is remembered as a mortal elven singer attached to a court that controlled who could hear its ancestral songs. When exiles were refused the music used to mourn their dead, she carried it beyond the court and taught it in a common tongue. Her punishment, according to the best-known account, was the surrender of her voice.

At the exiles' next funeral, every listener heard her sing, though she stood silent. Performers in distant settlements reported the same song that night. The oldest surviving shrines to Nivara date from the following generations. Her mortal existence and later divinity are broadly accepted; whether the miracle marked her ascension or revealed a change already completed remains disputed.

Today, Nivara's festivals begin with a performance offered without payment. Some temples teach that inspiration carries an obligation to share. Others emphasize the freedom of an artist to refuse a patron. Elaran's courts honor her while still arguing about which traditions should remain private.

Roads between strangers

Trade carried metal, salt, seeds, and stories between early settlements. Leth became a favored patron of travelers who survived uncertain roads. In the Tale of the Wrong Turning, a caravan misses its destination and discovers a valley able to feed a starving town. The story's oldest versions never identify Leth as mortal; later claimants to his ancestry have produced little agreement.

Sereva's worship also appears in early accounts of succession disputes. Her tale of the Borrowed Face concerns a trusted adviser who turns each member of a household against the others without speaking a single outright lie. The story helped establish the belief that truthful words can still serve betrayal.

By the age's end, fortified towns, durable trade routes, and ambitious schools had appeared. The First Courts continued in some regions, but growing populations demanded forms of cooperation that personal memory and inherited custom could no longer reliably supply.

Pacts with the living world

The First Courts remembered more neighbors than the communities now called civilized. Songs describe giant eagles carrying messages across high passes, watchful unicorns at protected springs, and forest guardians who accepted gifts or kept their distance according to old agreements. Some tales are ceremony rather than literal history. Yet the habit of asking a woodland keeper before cutting ancient trees survives, especially in Elaran, and travelers still leave particular groves undisturbed.

The Age of Great Works

About 4200 to 1300 BR



An artist’s reconstruction of the Great Works: shared learning made extraordinary architecture possible.

Selarin's ancient civilizations reached their greatest material achievements during this long age. Their learning accumulated across generations and crossed political boundaries.

They could build things modern practitioners can describe only in fragments. They were also dependent on institutions, trained workers, and agreements whose loss would eventually make those achievements impossible to maintain.

The Age of Great Works

About 4200 to 1300 BR / continued

Towers and covenant cities

The Concord of Towers began as an association of observatories and schools. Shared measurements allowed its members to coordinate distant workings, then to build gateways, suspended chambers, and instruments that influenced local weather. It never governed every land, and its member cities frequently disagreed. Its greatest accomplishment was making cooperation seem more profitable than secrecy for a time.

The Covenant Cities pursued another tradition: binding a lasting principle into a place. Protected burial grounds, halls without shadows, and sanctuaries governed by unusual rules survive from their age. They exchanged knowledge with the Concord and the surviving First Courts. The three traditions overlapped, borrowed freely, and sometimes claimed one another's achievements.

Veyra and the Unaltered Record

Veyra was a human recorder serving a council of covenant cities. When its rulers demanded that she amend a treaty to erase the rights of a defeated neighbor, she instead read the original before their assembled witnesses. Copies later appeared in archives too far apart for any ordinary messenger to have carried them.

Her cult dates her ascension to that public reading. Rival accounts describe years of persecution before she vanished from mortal life. Both agree on the part she played: preserving an obligation that powerful people wished to make disappear. Her priests now distinguish carefully between recording a claim and proving it true. Depositing a document in her temple does not make its contents sacred fact.

The square at Veycross

The Witness Court predates the modern city surrounding it. Within its original stone boundary, people cannot knowingly speak a falsehood. They may remain silent, speak narrowly, or repeat something mistaken that they honestly believe. The square does not force anyone to keep a promise after leaving it.

Veyra's followers became its best-known custodians. Avariel's judges regarded it as an aid to justice, while other priests warned that exact words could conceal an unjust bargain. Professional questioners and public readers developed around the court. Its original builders and intended purpose remain uncertain, despite confident claims made by several faiths.

An inheritance beyond present reach

Ordan's temples supported standards of measure and the obligations of builders. Ilyra's servants kept seasonal records. Mereth's communities established houses of healing along the routes. Their cooperation was substantial, but prosperity was uneven: some districts enjoyed controlled harvests while others supplied labor or materials on harsh terms.

Silent gates and unreachable structures remain across Selarin. A gateway may lack its distant counterpart; a weather tower may depend on instruments lost centuries ago. Some wonders still function but offer no known means of control. Even excellent modern magic cannot simply replace the societies that made them. Many waystones are also demonstrably ancient, though no accepted chronology explains the whole of their construction.

The enduring guardians

The Concord of Towers shaped more than stone. Records describe tireless sentinels at bridges, enchanted armor in public halls, and laboring constructs that held back rivers or lifted impossible weight. Certain keeps maintained trained griffons, while ambitious artificers attempted to breed or bind creatures suited to dangerous work. The greatest projects are lost, but a silent guardian at an abandoned gate may still obey an instruction that nobody remembers issuing. The wiser antiquarian treats a beautiful ruin as a place with rules, not an empty quarry.

The Age of Disagreement

About 1300 to 420 BR

The disputes that ended the ancient order began while much of it still prospered. Cities disagreed over access to gateways, the cost of maintaining great works, and who could change conditions shared with their neighbors. Records describe accusations that one realm's favorable weather had worsened another's harvest. Sometimes the evidence was compelling; sometimes a failed crop became a convenient reason to threaten a rival.

Cevrane and the Ledger of Winter

Cevrane first appears as a mortal human financier who supplied grain after a succession of white summers. He offered food against future labor, land, and inheritance. A family might survive one winter only to discover that its descendants remained liable for the price. His contracts acquired a terrible reputation for surviving every attempt to destroy or evade them.

At the event called the Closing of Accounts, witnesses reported his signature burning into ledgers in several cities at once. His agents began receiving answers to prayers addressed to him. His followers celebrate a mortal who made obligation endure beyond death; his opponents commemorate the same event as the elevation of exploitation into divine authority. Cevrane remains a lesser god, but his institutions reach far beyond any single throne.

Caelor and the Breaking of the Chain

Caelor was a mortal leader among communities bound to hereditary service. The oldest credible accounts agree that he refused a settlement offering freedom only to his own household. His followers seized the registers by which their service was enforced and held the western causeways long enough for entire districts to leave.

At the final crossing, Caelor disappeared into a storm. Survivors described a light moving against the wind and chains opening without a hand upon them. Shrines established by those survivors became centers of an enduring faith. Caelor's recognition as a greater power came over subsequent centuries as his worship spread. His ascension did not instantly end bondage, and his churches still debate when rebellion becomes a duty.

The Last Concord

Representatives of several traditions attempted one final broad settlement late in the age. Fragmentary records call it the Last Concord. Delegates agreed to common measures, restrictions on certain workings, and shared obligations that surviving copies describe only incompletely. Ordan's and Avariel's temples honor the attempt; Malrec's theologians argue that a single sovereign could have enforced what a council could not.

The agreement preserved peace in some places. Elsewhere, rulers withheld resources, altered its terms, or denied that their predecessors had possessed authority to bind them. What its most ambitious projects accomplished remains disputed. Modern claims to have recovered a complete account have repeatedly failed scholarly scrutiny.

Faith and faction

Thessar's worshippers resisted efforts to suppress every unpredictable change. Nharos offered stolen vitality to patrons afraid of losing their wealth or years. Varkhul's cults encouraged destruction as an answer to humiliation. Drazha's followers supplied hunters to regimes pursuing fugitives. Sereva's agents made reconciliation harder by exposing genuine wrongs at moments calculated to provoke revenge. The age ended with enough knowledge to build wonders, but too little trust to keep many of them working together.

When the wilds changed

As rival courts competed for magical advantage, some experiments altered the creatures around them. Accounts name manticores and chimeric predators along disputed borders, and describe valleys where familiar beasts no longer behaved in familiar ways. Every alarming animal was not the product of a wizard's ambition; pamphleteers often accused their enemies without proof. Nonetheless, the period left a long tradition of warded roads, strict rules for transporting dangerous specimens, and warnings about abandoned laboratories.

The Sundering Years

420 to 1 BR



The Seven Watches, as remembered in Teren’s devotional tradition.

The Sundering was a succession of failures and wars extending over four centuries. Its conventional beginning marks the closure of several important gateways within one generation.

Their loss disrupted food supplies and military alliances. Later disasters struck societies already struggling to repair the first damage. Some realms fell quickly; others survived long enough to receive refugees from places their grandchildren knew only by name.

The Sundering Years

420 to 1 BR / continued

Teren and the Seven Watches

Teren was a dwarven captain charged with a Crownspine passage during an evacuation. When his employers ordered the gates shut against foreign refugees, he opened the storehouses and kept the route clear. The account of the Seven Watches describes a defense maintained through successive assaults and a collapse that buried the approaches.

The final refugees said that Teren, already mortally wounded, remained at the gate after his companions had withdrawn. Later travelers found the passage standing and received aid from an armored figure bearing his broken shield. His worship took root among soldiers, smiths, and bridge keepers of many peoples. Avariel's church honors him as a divine companion whose service outranks obedience to an unjust command.

Khardun still treats the maintenance of safe passage as a public duty. Soldiers elsewhere swear by Teren before escorting civilians, although commanders have also invoked him to justify hopeless defenses that served no one. His priests consider the distinction essential.

Elsira and the House of Open Doors

Elsira kept a roadside house in country overwhelmed by winter refugees. The most widespread tradition describes her as a halfling widow, though later paintings often give her the appearance of their own community. Her household accepted strangers until its stores were exhausted. When armed men demanded the surrender of people sheltering inside, she barred the door against them and continued admitting those fleeing the cold through the kitchen.

Survivors remembered rooms that held more people than the building should have allowed. After Elsira's death, travelers began finding the same open doorway in distant storms. Accounts from separate refugee communities established her cult. Her ascension is widely accepted, while the particulars remain a cherished subject of local storytelling. Inns dedicated to her reserve a place for someone who cannot pay.

What could be saved

Mereth's healers and Sovan's funerary orders often traveled together. One tended survivors while the other recorded the dead, helping displaced families recover names and property claims. Veyra's archivists carried copies into mountain vaults. Nivara's performers preserved histories in forms that could travel without books. Their efforts explain why fragments endured even where institutions collapsed.

Claims that gods themselves were wounded or slain also belong to these centuries. Ruined sanctuaries name powers absent from the modern pantheon, but accounts disagree over their identities and fates. Possessing an old divine title is not proof of having inherited its power.

By the Sundering's end, surviving communities had established new roads and local authorities. At Veycross, envoys negotiated safe passage, recognized certain refugee claims, and agreed on measures for trade. Their settlement became the starting point of the Accord Reckoning. It restored particular relationships; peace across the entire continent took much longer.

The roads reclaimed

When maintained wards, bridges, and patrols failed, wolves and larger predators followed abandoned livestock through empty country. Trolls settled beneath neglected crossings; wyverns returned to cliffs once watched by garrisons; and some battlefields became places where the dead did not rest easily. Survivors learned to travel in groups, mark safe shelters, and distinguish a ruined village from a ruin still defended by ancient workings. Many customs dismissed as superstition began as practical answers to real dangers.

The Age of Inheritance

1 AR to the present year 742 AR



Fields, river traffic, and maintained roads sustain the kingdoms of the present.

The modern kingdoms grew through seven centuries of recovery, rivalry, and invention. They possess histories of their own, with institutions that respond to current needs.

Most people regard ancient ruins with a mixture of curiosity and caution. A repaired mill or dependable bridge usually matters more to a community than a lost wonder no one can operate.

The Age of Inheritance

1 AR to the present year 742 AR / continued

The making of the modern realms

Elaran's surviving forest courts renewed their mutual obligations in 63 AR. Their compact recognized stewardship over watersheds and forests while limiting the authority of any one court. The Crownspine holds established Khardun's present crown in 118 AR, accepting common defenses and standards for roads without surrendering their assemblies.

Caldris consolidated around coastal lords and chartered market towns in 204 AR. Its crown gained recognition partly by securing the southern route around the mountains. Aramere's River Compact of 287 AR bound several principalities to shared granaries and flood works. Its monarchs still defend their legitimacy through those obligations.

Vardane's northern assemblies recognized a common crown in 351 AR after years of disputes over pasture and fortified crossings. The Serathian imperial settlement followed in 426 AR, bringing the lower Auren and several eastern ports under one administration. Serath's rulers claimed ancient continuity, but the state they constructed depended on new bargains with cities and provincial elites.

The wars that fixed the borders

The Pass Disputes of 512 to 519 AR established many of Khardun's toll rights, although the interpretation of those rights still changes at inconvenient moments. Fighting on Elaran's southern edge produced the Woodland Articles of 558 AR, recognizing some protected forests while leaving disputed settlements outside any clear agreement.

The Grain War between Aramere and Serath lasted from 603 to 607 AR. Both sides suffered from interrupted trade, and neither gained the victory it had promised. The Auren Navigation Accord limited certain duties and established procedures for inspecting grain barges. Arguments now usually reach negotiators before armies, though merchants continue to fund armed escorts.

The Kharzai Dominion took its present form in 668 AR, when a military priesthood consolidated several plateau fortresses. Frontier clashes with Vardane and uneasy trade with Serath have continued since. It remains a smaller power, dangerous chiefly where terrain and discipline let it choose the terms of a confrontation.

Living in the present

The six major realms are not presently at war. Border incidents still occur, and peace depends on arrangements that require continual attention. Grain moves downriver, metals cross the mountain passes, and ports exchange goods that inland communities cannot produce. Temples, kinship, and commerce create loyalties that cross political lines.

Observers report unfamiliar migrations and scattered episodes of Breathweather, but disagree about whether they mark a larger change. Ancient inscriptions still attract scholars. New settlements grow beside old roads. Selarin offers room for ordinary ambition, generous deeds, and difficult choices without requiring every traveler to understand the world's oldest mysteries.

A world shared with wonders

Modern rulers cannot put every griffon, giant, or wyvern beyond their borders. Instead, they fund road watches, record sightings, and sometimes negotiate safe passage around known territories. Markets trade in alchemical reagents, feathers, hides, and protective charms, although counterfeit goods are common. Village bells may warn of a dangerous beast just as readily as fire or flood. Most journeys remain ordinary; what makes adventurers valuable is their willingness to travel where ordinary precautions are no longer enough.

The Greater Gods

History and realms

Greater and lesser describe the breadth of divine influence, not the worth of a god to an individual worshipper. Most people honor several powers as circumstances require. A sailor may pray to Thessar before departure, Leth during the voyage, and Elsira when seeking shelter. The moral descriptions below summarize established religious teaching; they do not dictate the character of every follower.

Avariel

Justice, protection, rightful authority. Lawful good.

The judge who accepted her own law; patron of accountable rulers and defenders. Her temples recognize Teren's sacrifice as a model of service.

Mereth

Mercy, healing, renewal, relief of suffering. Neutral good.

Her houses of healing crossed ancient political borders. Her orders sheltered survivors during the Sundering and still dispute restrictions on care.

Caelor

Freedom, hope, liberation. Chaotic good.

Once a mortal liberator; ascended at the Breaking of the Chain. His faith later gained the standing of a greater power.

Ordan

Law, boundaries, enduring order and works. Lawful neutral.

Associated with the world's foundations and the standards of the Great Works. Builders and magistrates invoke him when obligations must outlast individuals.

Ilyra

Seasons, fertility, living cycles and balance. True neutral.

Present in the oldest creation traditions. Her keepers preserve harvest records and teach stewardship adapted to the Long Breath.

Thessar

Storms, untamed places, unpredictable change. Chaotic neutral.

The wind that refused stillness in creation stories. Sailors, wanderers, and those living beyond settled borders seek his favor.

Malrec

Dominion, hierarchy, conquest, imposed order. Lawful evil.

His tradition credits command with bringing order to the first world. The Kharzai priesthood makes his authority the foundation of its state.

Nharos

Consumption, exploitation, stolen life and power. Neutral evil.

Opponent of Mereth in early sacred stories. Later cults promised rulers life and strength purchased at another's expense.

Varkhul

Devastation, wrath, catastrophic ruin. Chaotic evil.

Invoked by movements that sought destruction during the ancient collapse. His cults thrive on vengeance that has outgrown its original grievance.

Temples and their disagreements

No single church governs all worship of a god. Local orders can disagree over doctrine, wealth, and the duties of rulers. Shared devotion sometimes enables diplomacy where governments fail. It can also make disputes sharper when both sides believe they are defending a sacred obligation.

The gods answer through miracles, servants, signs, and the gifts of their faithful. Such contact has never produced a universally accepted account of the remote past. An answer given to one petitioner may address that person's need without settling a historian's question.

The Lesser Gods

History and realms

The lesser powers often stand closest to daily concerns. A remote village may have a substantial shrine to Elsira and no permanent temple to any greater god. Some lesser deities are older than the civilizations that worship them. Others have remembered mortal lives, preserved through testimony, cult records, and traditions shared across rival faiths.

Teren

Guardians, sworn service, protective arms. Lawful good.

A mortal dwarven captain who ascended after the Seven Watches. Patron of escorts, sentries, armorers, and those entrusted with another's safety.

Elsira

Hospitality, refuge, safe shelter. Neutral good.

The mortal keeper of the House of Open Doors. Her ascension is remembered through the refugee accounts of the Sundering.

Nivara

Art, inspiration, illusion, creative magic. Chaotic good.

A mortal elven singer associated with the Open Song. Her cult arose among the First Peoples and spread with traveling performers.

Veyra

Testimony, records, agreements, preserved knowledge. Lawful neutral.

A mortal human recorder who upheld the Unaltered Record. Her custodians administer the Witness Court and archives in many realms.

Sovan

Death, remembrance, the passage and care of souls. True neutral.

An ancient power whose mortal origin is not part of the established tradition. His orders keep the identities of the dead and protect burial places.

Leth

Fortune, wandering, discoveries by chance. Chaotic neutral.

Known from early road tales, with no accepted mortal identity. Travelers toss him a coin while admitting that good luck seldom comes with an explanation.

Cevrane

Debt, ownership, binding bargains, possessive wealth. Lawful evil.

A mortal human financier who ascended at the Closing of Accounts. His temples enforce claims that other faiths may regard as profoundly unjust.

Sereva

Envy, betrayal, secrets that destroy trust. Neutral evil.

Appears in early household and succession legends. Her cults cultivate confidence before turning private knowledge against its owners.

Drazha

Cruelty, terror, predation, the murderous hunt. Chaotic evil.

Ancient tales portray the hunter who refuses to stop. Her followers make pursuit and fear into ends in themselves.

Remembered ascensions

Nivara, Veyra, Cevrane, Caelor, Teren, and Elsira are widely recognized as having been mortal. Their stories differ in origin and consequence. Faiths dispute the precise means of each transformation, and none preserves a generally accepted procedure by which it can be repeated.

Temples sometimes call a hero a saint, chosen servant, or divine companion without claiming an ascension. Those titles alone do not establish godhood. The distinction matters in a world where ambitious rulers have repeatedly announced a destiny their successors quietly stopped mentioning.

Elaran and Khardun

History and realms

Elaran

Elaran occupies the northwestern forests between the Western Sea and the Crownspine. Rainmere's colder woodlands give way southward to wetter temperate valleys. Its settlements are comparatively few, but ancient living works and long traditions of magical study give the realm influence beyond its population. Sylvaen is its capital; Lethariel connects the forest courts to western sea trade.

Elves predominate in its institutions, alongside established human, gnome, and other communities. Authority rests with watershed courts whose obligations concern forests, rivers, and the people living among them. The High Crown represents their common interests. High Queen Aereth Vael presently holds that office, but major changes require the cooperation of the courts. She favors negotiated boundaries with Caldris; several southern wardens believe concessions only invite further settlement.

Elaran traces cultural descent from the First Courts without possessing all their knowledge. Some inherited wonders continue by means their caretakers cannot reproduce. Arguments over who may enter sacred groves or copy ancestral songs bring Nivara's teaching into tension with inherited privileges. Ilyra's worship is widespread, and Sovan's custodians maintain records that follow families across several human generations.

The realm exports skilled craft, carefully regulated timber, and rare products of its forests. Its southern boundary remains unsettled in places, where Caldran charters overlap older claims of stewardship. Travelers encounter elaborate hospitality followed by equally elaborate restrictions. A character from Elaran may inherit duties to a particular valley without being wealthy, noble, or welcome in every court.

Wardens of Elaran's deeper forests also record great stags, elusive unicorns, and owlbears along disputed cutting roads. These are creatures of their own habits and territories, not reliable servants of any court. Communities post seasonal notices when nesting grounds or old groves should be given a wider berth.

Khardun

Khardun occupies the Crownspine's holds, inhabited valleys, and principal crossings. Its northern settlements face long winters; sheltered districts such as Ember Vale support farming that outsiders often overlook. Khar Duram is the royal seat, while Durnhold and Stonepass help bind the mountain routes into a defensible network.

The kingdom's predominantly dwarven institutions preserve the rights of powerful hold assemblies. High King Borun Durnak governs through their cooperation. His current priority is keeping passage open and securing grain agreements without making the holds dependent on a single foreign supplier. Assembly speakers can frustrate him by withholding labor or insisting that a disputed toll is an ancestral right.

Khardun's records survived the Sundering unusually well, but preservation has not guaranteed complete understanding. Vaults contain measurements whose instruments are gone and instructions that assume skills no longer taught. Ordan's builders and Teren's guardians share responsibility for public works. Maintaining a bridge is treated as a serious civic obligation, especially where a failure could isolate an entire valley.

Metalwork, mining, engineering, and tolls support Khardun's power. Herding and terraced agriculture matter equally to its survival, supplemented by imported food and timber agreements with its neighbors. The mountain barrier gives the kingdom leverage; the same barrier makes every blocked route costly. Khardun welcomes skilled strangers who accept a hold's obligations, although citizenship and access to old workings require more than a successful trade.

High passes through the Crownspine are known for griffon aeries, mountain trolls, and occasional wyvern flights. Dwarven roadmasters mark nests and rockfalls with equal care. Stories of ancient dragons remain part of the holds' written traditions, although direct sightings are rare and often disputed.

Caldris and Aramere

History and realms

Caldris

Caldris lies west and southwest of the Crownspine, extending around the range's southern end. Farms, market towns, wooded uplands, and a mild coast give it a varied economy. Caer Calden is the royal capital. Veycross, home of the Witness Court, gives the realm diplomatic importance far beyond its borders. Westhaven supports coastal trade, while smaller towns connect agricultural districts to the main roads.

Queen Marwen Calder shares authority with landed houses and chartered towns. Her government depends on bargaining over taxation and public works. Town councils want dependable roads and predictable dues; noble families resist decisions that diminish their inherited jurisdictions. The queen's strongest supporters see common law and commerce as ways to bind those interests together.

Veycross is central to that ambition. Its custodians, public readers, and professional questioners serve foreign envoys as well as local families. Avariel and Veyra have influential temples there, but their clergy cannot guarantee that every truthful agreement is fair. Cevrane's representatives also conduct business in the city, watched closely by advocates who assist people unable to afford expert advice.

Caldris has substantial resources without Serath's urban concentration or Aramere's immense grain basin. It competes with Aramere over the southern road and disputes woodland settlement with Elaran. Rural magic tends to be personal and local. A character from Caldris may understand market rights, household obligations, and the practical importance of a bridge before knowing anything about ancient empires.

Charter roads lead through country where trolls and great hunting beasts occasionally threaten isolated crossings. Coastal authorities record unusual sea-life and storm-season wrecks; inland wardens post warnings at old ruins rather than promising that every relic has been made safe.

Aramere

Aramere occupies the central and south-central basin east of the lower Crownspine. Its river plains and settled farmland support one of Selarin's largest populations. Aurenhall governs the kingdom; Dunmere serves its downstream commerce. Smaller settlements such as Fairmead, Northbridge, and Barleywick reflect a land whose strength rests on harvests and the movement of food.

King Edric Vaun rules a crown assembled from older principalities. The River Council gives provincial houses and major towns a voice in grain reserves, flood works, and navigation. A ruler who neglects those duties risks more than discontent: the River Compact provides a political language for demanding action. Edric favors investment in roads toward Caldris to reduce reliance on Serathian customs houses.

Aramere's ancient works cluster around its oldest districts. Waystones appear in village greens, beside mills, and within later buildings. Local ceremonies may be centuries old without preserving an explanation of the stones themselves. Ilyra's seasonal keepers, Mereth's healers, and Elsira's refuge houses have strong followings. Granaries and emergency shelters embody religious duties as well as public policy.

Its northern grasslands meet Vardane without a clean natural barrier. Pasture rights and fortified crossings remain recurrent disputes. Downstream, Serath controls the cheapest route to eastern markets. Western Aramere offers easier contact with Khardun and Caldris: Threeways is a natural meeting point, and nearby Hearthglen belongs to the quieter network of farming communities around it. Such villages are part of a powerful kingdom even when royal authority feels several days' ride away.

The kingdom's prosperity depends on ordinary precautions against extraordinary risks. Rural councils maintain warning bells for owlbears and dire wolves, boatmen exchange accounts of dangerous river creatures, and traveling inspectors sometimes consult practitioners when old works behave unexpectedly.

Vardane and the Serathian Empire

History and realms

Vardane

Vardane stretches across the northern interior, from the Crownspine's eastern approaches toward the Blackglass frontier. Its far north has cold woodland and open, wintry country; farther south lie grasslands, sheltered farms, and the crossings through which commerce moves. Valdren is the capital. Greywatch faces the eastern frontier, while Stagford connects southern pasture country to Aramere.

King Osric Renn depends on regional assemblies and marcher lords whose local authority often exceeds the crown's practical reach. His standing rests on settling disputes and coordinating defense. Maintaining winter shelters and reserves is an established obligation of landholders. Assemblies can be unforgiving when a lord's household remains comfortable while travelers die on the road outside it.

Vardane has less conspicuous magic than the southern realms. Its people still seek blessings, consult local practitioners, and honor the gods. They are wary of grand projects whose promises exceed what a community can verify. Teren's guardians, Elsira's shelter keepers, and followers of Thessar are especially visible. Memories of the Sundering survive through practical customs as much as written histories.

The kingdom's scattered population limits the armies it can sustain, but experienced riders and defensible settlements make conquest difficult. Relations with Aramere fluctuate over grazing and crossings. Along the Kharzai approaches, raids coexist with prisoner exchanges and negotiated local truces. Frontier commanders disagree about whether concentrated defenses or more flexible patrols best protect the people between the forts.

In the northern reaches, winter wolves, great hunting birds, and solitary giants belong to travelers' warnings alongside ice and hunger. Frontier patrols share monster sightings with local shelters, where a believable account may save the next caravan a dangerous detour.

The Serathian Empire

Serath controls the lower River Auren, the southeastern plain, and much of the eastern coast. Serathis is the imperial capital; Aurentide serves the estuary. Veloria strengthens eastern maritime trade, while Caltheris and Goldfield give the empire direct access to the Southern Sea. These southern ports help provincial merchants conduct business beyond the river corridor.

Empress Talessa Orien governs through provincial officials, influential cities, and an imperial court. The empire has Selarin's strongest concentration of urban wealth and modern magical institutions. Its academies train practitioners, compete for patronage, and sponsor excavations. None has recovered general command of the greatest ancient works, despite claims that occasionally impress the court before collapsing under examination.

Serath's rulers present the empire as heir to an older order. Official ceremonies borrow ancient titles, while historians argue about how much continuity those titles represent. Ordan's law and Veyra's records support imperial administration. Avariel's jurists insist that authority carries duties to the governed. Malrec's ideas attract some advocates of expansion, but his worship does not define the empire as a whole.

The court wants reliable grain, customs revenue, and secure trade routes. Those interests make Aramere both essential partner and persistent rival. Southern port councils resist policies favoring the capital's river merchants. Provincial commanders watch the highland approaches, while intermediaries trade with Kharzai. Serath can exert pressure through credit and inspections long before it considers deploying an army.

In Serath, licensed alchemists and traders sell substances taken from uncommon beasts, while customs officials scrutinize shipments of venom and living specimens. Imperial officers investigate threats to major routes; they rarely claim that every ruin or distant headland lies under their protection.

The Kharzai Dominion

Fortresses of the Blackglass country

The Dominion holds a smaller territory in the northeastern Blackglass country, beyond Vardane's eastern marches and north of Serath's settled interior. Exposed volcanic ground, cold mountains, and scarce dependable water concentrate its population around fortified ravines. Kharzag is its seat of power; Iron Gate guards an important approach. Ashmarket and Cinderwell sustain trade and supplies that the fortresses cannot produce alone.

Archmagus Vezrak Khar, a human spellcaster who rules from Kharzag, stands above the Dominion's military councils and the powerful priesthood devoted to Malrec. Public proclamations praise his mastery of discipline, law, and arcane learning. Foreign observers describe a severe and calculating ruler whose decrees are carried out by generals, temple officers, and appointed magistrates. His authority is formidable, although no single official governs every settlement without local resistance.

The Dominion enforces rigid hierarchy and compulsory labor, rewarding service that strengthens its fortresses and supply lines. Hobgoblins remain prominent among its military officers, but its inhabitants include many ancestries, subject communities, and dissenters who reject the ruling institutions' ambitions. Its government is not the inevitable character of any people. Border merchants may encounter skilled smiths, cautious negotiators, and families more concerned with surviving the next winter than spreading their ruler's power.

Terraced cultivation, hardy livestock, reservoirs, and mineral trade support the strongholds. Their rulers seek secure water and defensible access to better land, avoiding open campaigns where larger neighbors could bring their full resources to bear. The Blackglass heights shelter ash drakes, wyverns, and dangerous creatures drawn to warm fissures; patrol orders treat such hazards as seriously as enemy scouts. Serathian intermediaries offer markets, while Vardane maintains an uneasy mixture of confrontation and negotiation. The Dominion's stonewardens forbid interference with local waystones, which they regard as sacred monuments of restraint and authority.

Powers Beyond the Crowns

Faith, learning, and trade

The Custodians of the Witness Court

First Witness Sabren Holt represents Veycross's custodians in dealings with rulers and foreign envoys. The office protects access to the court and maintains records of public proceedings. Its authority depends on trust across borders, so the custodians resist being treated as an instrument of Caldris. Their questioners and archives make them useful to anyone trying to establish what was actually promised.

The Fellowship of Open Doors

Mother Hessa Vale coordinates a network of Elsiran refuges and traveling stewards. Its houses arrange shelter, carry news about dangerous roads, and help displaced people locate relatives. Local houses retain considerable independence. Their willingness to shelter people whom a ruler wants returned can turn a charitable institution into an unexpected diplomatic force.

The Collegium of Surviving Works

Provost Istran Pell leads a Serathis-based association of scholars, surveyors, and practitioners with correspondents across the realms. It studies ancient structures and supports expeditions to document them. Its members disagree over excavation rights, public access to discoveries, and the demands of wealthy patrons. Provincial rulers welcome useful knowledge while watching for attempts to carry their inheritance abroad.

The Auren Factors and the Ledger Houses

Speaker Mara Venn represents a league of merchants whose warehouses and barges connect Aramere with Serath. The Auren Factors favor predictable duties and navigable rivers, giving them reasons to pressure both governments toward peace. They are commercial partners rather than a single sovereign power.

Cevrane's Ledger Houses finance ventures across the same routes. A senior broker active along these routes, Cassian Voss, offers courts and merchants access to credit at terms carefully designed to preserve his institutions' influence. Their contracts are public business, even where their theology is unwelcome. Between crowns, temples, and lenders, a modest bargain can acquire consequences that reach far beyond the town where it was made.